# NESS WONDERS

Augmented Reality Guide to Chichén Itzá

# The Complete User Guide

*Every screen, every feature and every monument — described in full detail*

154 scannable monuments · 2D & 3D live maps · AR scanner · AI agents · offline mode

Prepared November 14, 2026

# Table of Contents

1. Welcome to NESS Wonders
2. About Chichén Itzá
3. Getting Started
4. Reading the Site Map (2D & 3D)
5. Your Live Position & GPS
6. Using the AR Scanner
7. Using AR Navigation
8. Landmark Detail Pages
9. The AI Historian (Ask the Guide)
10. The AI Storyteller (Cultural Stories)
11. The AI Navigator (Voice Walking Directions)
12. Audio Narration & Guided Tour
13. Route Planner & Must-See Visit
14. Proximity Alerts
15. Offline Mode
16. Photo Gallery & Sharing
17. Your Profile, Settings & AI Agents
18. Languages & Accessibility
19. Troubleshooting & FAQ
20. Practical Visitor Information
21. Site Etiquette & Responsible Visiting
22. Glossary of Maya Terms
23. Complete Monument Directory (154 sites)

# 1. Welcome to NESS Wonders

NESS Wonders is an augmented reality (AR) companion for visitors to the ancient Maya city of Chichén Itzá. Using your phone's camera, you can scan monuments to receive AI-powered explanations, follow a glowing pink path through the site, listen to narrated stories as you walk, and always see where you are on both the 2D and 3D site maps.

The app is designed to be used hands-free and in bright sunlight: large controls, high-contrast text, audio narration for long-form content, and offline support so the guide keeps working when the site's mobile signal does not.

## What you can do

• Explore — open a cinematic 3D model of the site, or switch to a flat 2D map, both of which show your live position.

• Scan — point your camera at a monument and receive an instant AI explanation plus a surprising fact.

• Listen — hear any monument narrated aloud, or run the whole site as a guided audio tour.

• Plan — generate a route from the time you have and the monuments you care about.

• Ask — talk with the AI Historian about any landmark, hear cultural stories from the Storyteller, and get walking directions from the AI Navigator.

• Collect — every monument you visit is recorded in your profile, and you can export a shareable journey card.

• Carry it with you — download this complete guide as a PDF and the site data for offline use.

## What you need

• A modern phone browser (Safari or Chrome recommended) with camera and location permissions.

• An internet connection for the first load, AI answers and audio generation.

• Headphones for the best audio experience in crowded areas.

• A portable charger — continuous camera and 3D rendering use battery quickly.

# 2. About Chichén Itzá

Chichén Itzá is one of the most important archaeological sites in the Americas. Located on the Yucatán Peninsula in present-day Mexico, it was a major Maya political, religious and commercial centre from roughly 600 to 1200 CE. Its architecture blends Maya and central Mexican styles, reflecting its role as a cultural crossroads.

In 1988 the site was designated a UNESCO World Heritage Site, and in 2007 it was named one of the New Seven Wonders of the World. El Castillo — the great step pyramid at its heart — is a masterpiece of Maya astronomy and engineering.

## A short chronology

• c. 600–900 CE — Chichén Itzá rises as a regional power; the earliest large constructions appear.

• c. 900–1200 CE — The city's golden age. El Castillo, the Great Ball Court, the Temple of the Warriors and the Observatory take their present form.

• c. 1250 CE — Power shifts to Mayapán; Chichén Itzá declines and is gradually abandoned.

• 1526–1546 — Spanish expeditions pass through the ruined city.

• 1841–1843 — John Lloyd Stephens and Frederick Catherwood bring Chichén Itzá to world attention.

• 1904–1911 — Large-scale excavation begins; the Sacred Cenote is dredged.

• 1988 — UNESCO World Heritage listing. 2007 — Named a New Wonder of the World.

## Architecture

Stone was cut and fitted without metal tools or wheeled transport. Builders used corbel vaults, stucco reliefs and serpent imagery, and oriented major structures to the movements of the sun, moon and Venus. The Great Ball Court is the largest known in Mesoamerica, and the Temple of the Warriors is fronted by a forest of carved columns.

## The astronomy of El Castillo

Each of the pyramid's four stairways has 91 steps; with the top platform that makes 365 — the length of the solar year. At the equinoxes, the late-afternoon sun casts a series of triangular shadows down the northern balustrade that joins the carved serpent head at its base, an effect known as the descent of Kukulcán.

## The Sacred Cenote

A cenote is a natural sinkhole exposing groundwater. The Sacred Cenote at Chichén Itzá was a place of pilgrimage and offering; excavations in the early twentieth century recovered jade, gold, copal incense and human remains. Visitors may look down to the water but swimming is not permitted.

# 3. Getting Started

## First launch

1. Open the app in your phone's browser. A short three-step walkthrough introduces scanning, the pink path and the AI guide. Tap "Next" to advance, or "Skip" to go straight in.

2. Grant camera access when the AR scanner or AR navigation asks for it.

3. Grant location access so your live position can be drawn on the 2D and 3D maps and so proximity alerts can work.

4. Pick your language from the globe button in the top-right corner of the Explore screen. Every screen, AI answer and narration follows your choice.

## The home screen

• Begin AR Journey — opens the interactive site map and starts exploring.

• Scan a Monument — jumps straight to the AR scanner.

• Plan Your Route — builds a personalised route from duration and interests.

• Gallery — your captured photos.

• AI Agents — access to the Historian, Storyteller and Navigator.

• Download User Guide (PDF) — saves this document for offline reference.

• Live stats count the monuments in the app and the languages supported.

## Bottom navigation

A navigation bar at the bottom of the screen switches between Home, Explore and Scan, and opens your Profile. AR screens are full-screen camera views — use the back arrow in the top-left to return.

## Permissions, and why each one exists

• Camera — required by the AR Scanner, AR Navigation and photo capture. The feed is processed on your device and is never uploaded.

• Location — used to place your live position on the maps, to measure real distances to monuments, to advance a guided tour when you reach a stop, and to trigger proximity alerts.

• Notifications — used for proximity and opening-hours alerts. You can turn notifications off at any time in system settings.

## Your account and profile

Your profile records every monument you have visited, lets you revisit your journey card, download documents and control your settings. Nothing you capture is public unless you choose to share it.

# 4. Reading the Site Map (2D & 3D)

The Explore screen is built around the site map. A dark, cinematic model of Chichén Itzá sits behind every control, and a fluorescent pink path links the monuments in the recommended visit order.

## The 3D map

• Drag with one finger to orbit the site; pinch to zoom in on a pyramid or out to the whole city.

• Tap a monument to select it — the structure lifts slightly, its pink ring pulses, and a detail card slides up.

• Structures are modelled by type: stepped temples, platforms, the ball court, the domed observatory, colonnades, residences and the ringed cenote.

• Monuments on your active route glow brighter than the rest, and the path itself becomes a raised pink tube.

## The 2D map

• Tap the 2D/3D button to flatten the map. Markers become numbered pills connected by a dashed pink line — ideal for a quick orientation or a screenshot.

• Numbers follow the recommended visit order, so stop 1 is the first place to walk to.

• Tap any marker to open the same detail card used in 3D.

## Your live position — on both maps

Your position is drawn as a cyan dot with a pulsing halo and a "You are here" label. It appears in the same place in the 2D map and on the 3D ground plane, so switching views never loses you. The cyan GPS pill at the top of the Explore screen confirms that a location fix is live.

## Explore and Explain modes

• Explore keeps the detail card short: a name, a category and a two-line summary.

• Explain expands the card with Why It Matters, Historical Context, Did You Know facts and a visitor tip, and can draw monument name labels above the 3D map.

## The pink path

The path is generated from the recommended visit order, or from your own route when a tour or planned route is active. Follow it on the map, or let AR Navigation place it on the ground in front of you.

# 5. Your Live Position & GPS

NESS Wonders converts your device coordinates onto the app's stylised site map, which is why the same cyan marker can be shown on a flat 2D plan and on the 3D model. The conversion is a simple linear projection, so positions are visual guides rather than survey-grade coordinates.

## How it behaves

• The app watches your position continuously while a map screen is open, so the marker moves as you walk.

• High-accuracy mode is requested; on phones this can take ten to thirty seconds outdoors for the first reliable fix.

• Accuracy depends on sky visibility: open plazas are good, dense trees and colonnades are poor.

## If the marker is missing

• Check that the GPS pill on the Explore screen reads "GPS on". If it reads "GPS off", no fix has arrived yet.

• Allow location access for the browser in your phone settings, then reload the app.

• Step outside, away from trees and buildings, and wait a moment.

• Desktop browsers and laptops without GPS often report no position at all — the marker will not appear there.

• Battery saver modes can suppress location updates; disable them while exploring.

## Privacy

Your coordinates are used only to draw the marker, measure distances and trigger alerts. They are not published in your profile, not attached to your journey card and not shared with other visitors.

# 6. Using the AR Scanner

The scanner is the heart of the app: it identifies a monument and returns an AI explanation with a vivid "Did you know?" highlight.

## Scanning a monument

1. Open the scanner from the home screen or the bottom navigation.
2. Point the camera at the monument and fill the frame with it.
3. Tap the pink "Tap to Scan" button.
4. Read the AI explanation, or tap "Listen" to hear it narrated.
5. Tap "Full Details" for the complete landmark page, or "Scan Again" to identify another monument.

## The Scannable Points map

Not sure what to scan? The "Points" button opens the 2D map with all 154 monuments. Your live position is shown there too, so you can see which monument is closest before you walk. Tap a marker to set it as the next scan target; the banner confirms your choice.

## Capturing photos

• Tap "Capture" to freeze a frame from the camera.

• Retake, save to your device, or share through your phone's share sheet — including straight to Instagram.

• Captured photos are kept in the in-app gallery, tagged with the monument name.

# 7. Using AR Navigation

AR Navigation projects a fluorescent pink path onto the ground through your camera, guiding you from where you stand to the monument you chose.

1. Open a landmark from the map and tap "Navigate Here in AR".
2. Allow camera access if prompted.
3. Hold the phone at a comfortable walking angle, camera facing slightly towards the ground.
4. Follow the pink path and the turn-by-turn instructions above it.
5. Watch the distance countdown in the top bar; when you arrive, a card offers the full story.

## Tips

• The path is a perspective overlay, not a survey line — always watch the real ground around you.

• Keep moving; the path updates as your position changes.

• If the path seems to drift, look at the horizon briefly to help the compass settle.

• Exit at any time with the back arrow.

# 8. Landmark Detail Pages

Every landmark has a full page gathering everything known about it in one place.

**Hero image**

A photograph or illustration of the monument.

**Category & era**

The structure type (temple, platform, ball court, cenote, observatory, residential, column group) and its approximate period.

**Description**

What the monument is and what it looks like today.

**Listen to story**

Generates spoken narration of the name, description and significance.

**Why It Matters**

Cultural, religious and historical importance.

**Historical Context**

The people who built it and its role in the city.

**Did You Know?**

Surprising facts that bring the stone to life.

**Visitor Tip**

What to look for when standing in front of it.

**Navigate Here in AR**

Starts AR navigation from your live position.

**Ask the guide**

Opens the AI Historian for questions about this monument.

# 9. The AI Historian (Ask the Guide)

The Historian is a conversational guide that knows the monument you are standing in front of. Open it with "Ask the guide" on a landmark card or page, then type or speak your question.

- Ask anything: who built it, what the carvings mean, what was found inside, how it was dated.
- Tap the microphone to speak instead of typing — your voice is transcribed and sent as a question.
- Answers are written in your chosen language and can be narrated aloud.
- Access runs on a paid time window; the remaining time is shown in your profile.

## Good questions to try

*"What happens on the pyramid at the equinox?" · "Why does the ball court have such a strange acoustic echo?" · "What did the excavators find in the cenote?" · "How do we know when this was built?"*

# 10. The AI Storyteller (Cultural Stories)

The Storyteller turns the archaeology into narrative. Instead of facts, you get a scene: the sound of the market, the weight of the stone, the people who climbed the stairs.

- Open a landmark and choose the cultural story option.
- The story arrives in your language and can be read or listened to.
- Ask follow-ups to continue the same story or move to a different monument.
- Stories are generated on demand, so each visit can feel different.
- Like the Historian, the Storyteller shares the paid access window shown in your profile.

# 11. The AI Navigator (Voice Walking Directions)

The Navigator is a spoken guide for the walk itself. It knows your position, the monument you are heading to, and the shape of the site between the two.

- Open it from a landmark page and it immediately begins giving directions.
- Directions are spoken aloud, so you can keep your eyes on the ground.
- Ask follow-up questions out loud — "how much further?", "what is on my left?"
- If no GPS fix has arrived it asks you to confirm where you are and continues from there.

# 12. Audio Narration & Guided Tour

All long-form content can be spoken aloud, so you can walk and listen with the phone in your pocket.

• Tap "Listen to story" on a landmark page, or "Listen" on the map card, to narrate that monument.

• Tap "Start Tour" on the Explore screen for a guided audio tour that narrates every stop in order along the pink path; tap "Stop Tour" to end it.

• During a tour the active stop glows brighter, the tour chips at the bottom let you jump to any stop, and the next stop begins glowing once you reach the current one.

• A floating mini-player stays above the bottom navigation with play, pause, next and stop controls.

• Audio continues while you move between screens.

• The first playback of any story takes a few seconds while the audio is generated.

# 13. Route Planner & Must-See Visit

The route planner turns your available time and interests into a walking order.

1. Open "Plan Your Route" from the home screen.
2. Choose a visit duration from one hour to a full day.
3. Select the categories you care about — temples, ball courts, cenotes, observatories, platforms, residences, colonnades.
4. Tap "Generate Route" to see the stops drawn on the 3D map and listed underneath.
5. Tap "Start Guided Tour" to hear each stop narrated, or "Navigate to first stop" to begin walking.

• Must-See Visit ignores duration and returns the essential highlights of the site.

• À la carte mode lets you build a route by tapping monuments yourself; the count and a clear button are shown as you go.

• Your live position is drawn on the planning map, so you can see how far the first stop is.

# 14. Proximity Alerts

Proximity alerts tell you when you are standing near a monument, so you never walk past something worth scanning.

• Turn them on with the proximity pill on the Explore screen, or from the switch in your profile.

• Within about five metres of a monument the phone gives a soft double vibration and shows a card with the monument name.

• Each monument alerts once per visit, so you are not disturbed repeatedly.

• The card offers Navigate and Details actions, or dismiss it and keep walking.

• Alerts need location permission to work.

# 15. Offline Mode

Mobile coverage inside the site is uneven. Download the site data before you arrive and the map, monument texts and directory keep working without a connection.

• Tap the "Offline" button on the Explore screen to save all monument data to your device.

• Once saved, the button reads "Saved" and the app shows an offline banner whenever the connection drops.

• Tap again at any time to refresh the saved copy.

• Offline you can still browse the map, open every monument page and read the full text; AI answers and new audio generation need a connection.

• Save this PDF too — it is the complete guide, available with no signal at all.

# 16. Photo Gallery & Sharing

Photos captured in the scanner are stored on your device and collected in the gallery.

- Open Gallery from the home screen to see a grid of your photos, newest first.
- Each thumbnail notes the monument where it was taken.
- Tap a photo to open it full screen, then share it to Instagram or any other app.
- On devices without a share sheet the photo is saved to your camera roll instead.
- Delete any photo from the full-screen viewer.

## Your journey card

Your profile can export a square card showing how many monuments you have visited, ready to share.

# 17. Your Profile, Settings & AI Agents

Everything personal to you lives in one place.

## Journey

• A progress ring counts the monuments you have visited against the full directory.

• The visit history lists each monument in the order you reached it, with the date.

• Share to Instagram exports your journey card.

## AI agents dashboard

• The Historian and the Storyteller each show the time remaining on your access window, counting down live.

• When the time runs out the row reads "Expired" and the button below takes you to the access page to top up.

• Access is purchased in blocks of time and unlocks both expert agents at once.

## Downloads

• Download User Guide (PDF) — this complete document.

• Download Terms & Policy (PDF) — the terms you accepted at registration.

## Settings

• Opening / closing alerts — a daily reminder before Chichén Itzá opens and before it closes.

• Map labels — show monument names above the 3D map in Explain mode.

• Proximity alerts — the same switch as the Explore screen, kept in sync.

# 18. Languages & Accessibility

The interface, the AI answers and the narrated audio are all available in the language you choose from the globe button.

- English, Spanish, Chinese, Hindi, Arabic, French, Portuguese, German, Italian and Japanese.
- Right-to-left languages such as Arabic switch the whole interface to RTL layout automatically.
- The choice is remembered between visits.

## Accessibility

- Every long text can be narrated — useful in bright sun or for visitors with low vision.
- Voice input lets you ask questions without typing.
- Large, high-contrast controls are used throughout for one-handed outdoor use.
- Text is resizable through your phone or browser settings.

# 19. Troubleshooting & FAQ

**The camera view is black.**
Camera permission was refused or another app is using the camera. Close other camera apps, allow access in browser settings and reload.

**I cannot see my position on the map.**
Wait for a location fix outdoors. If the GPS pill still reads "GPS off", allow location in browser settings, disable battery saver, and reload. Laptops without GPS cannot show a position.

**The scan returns something unexpected.**
Fill the frame with one monument, avoid heavy backlight, and try again from a different angle. Narrow or partially restored structures are the hardest to read.

**Audio will not play.**
Check the media volume and that the phone is not on silent. The first playback takes a few seconds while the audio is generated — a connection is required.

**The AI agents are locked.**
The access window has expired. Open the agents dashboard in your profile and top up the time.

**The map is empty.**
The monument data has not loaded. Connect once, or tap the Offline button to save the data for later.

**The AR path drifts away from the walkway.**
GPS accuracy varies. Follow the real path and use the on-screen distance as a guide rather than a precise measurement.

**Notifications do not arrive.**
Allow notifications for the browser in your phone settings, and keep the app open in a tab while you rely on them.

# 20. Practical Visitor Information

## Planning your visit

• Arrive early or late in the day to avoid heat and crowds; March brings the equinox shadow on El Castillo.

• Allow three to four hours for the main monuments, plus extra time to scan and listen at each stop.

• The site is largely open and unshaded — sunscreen, a hat, comfortable shoes and water are essential.

• Bring a portable charger; camera, 3D rendering and audio drain the battery quickly.

## On site

• Download the offline data and this PDF before you arrive.

• Headphones make narration far clearer in a crowded plaza.

• Use the route planner if your time is limited, and the must-see route if it is very limited.

• Look for shade and water stations between distant groups of monuments.

# 21. Site Etiquette & Responsible Visiting

- Chichén Itzá is a protected World Heritage site and a sacred place to living Maya communities.
- Never climb on restricted structures, touch carvings or remove stones or plants.
- Stay on marked paths and respect barriers and staff instructions.
- Some structures are closed without notice for conservation or ceremony — never enter closed areas.
- Ask before photographing people, and keep voices low in ceremonial spaces.
- Drone use is restricted and generally not permitted.
- Take your litter with you; the site's water and soil are fragile.

# 22. Glossary of Maya Terms

**Cenote**
A natural sinkhole exposing groundwater, sacred in Maya belief and a source of water.

**Kukulcán**
The feathered serpent deity; the Maya name behind the equinox shadow on El Castillo.

**Chac Mool**
A reclining stone figure holding a receptacle, often found at temple entrances.

**Ball court**
An I-shaped court for the ritual ball game; the Chichén Itzá court is the largest known.

**Corbel vault**
A vault built by stepping stones inward rather than with a true arch.

**Stela**
A carved stone slab bearing rulers, dates or ritual imagery.

**Metate**
A grinding stone used for maize.

**Observatory**
A structure aligned for astronomical observation; El Caracol is the best known here.

**Sacbe**
A raised white road linking plazas, buildings and cities.

**Copal**
Resin burned as incense in offerings and ceremonies.

# 23. Complete Monument Directory

*154 scannable landmarks at Chichén Itzá, in the recommended visit order.*

## 1. The Altar of the Center

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

An altar at the cosmic center for offerings to the world tree.

**Why It Matters**

It connected the underworld, earth, and sky through ritual.

**Historical Context**

The altar received the most sacred offerings of the precinct.

**Did You Know?**

%æ It received offerings to the world tree.

%æ A center glyph marks the altar.

**Visitor Tip**

Stand here to feel the center of the cosmos.

## 2. The Temple of the Center

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A temple at the symbolic center of the Maya cosmos.

**Why It Matters**

It honored the world tree and the axis of the cosmos.

**Historical Context**

The temple was the precinct's spiritual anchor.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Its altar faced all four directions.

%æ A ceiba glyph marks the temple.

**Visitor Tip**

Find the ceiba glyph on the temple.

## 3. The Platform of the Center

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A platform marking the symbolic heart of the ceremonial precinct.

**Why It Matters**

It was the ritual center of the sacred layout.

**Historical Context**

The platform stood at the crossing of the four directions.

**Did You Know?**

%æ It sits at the crossing of the directional axes.

%æ It was the precinct's ritual heart.

**Visitor Tip**

Stand at the center of the four directions.

## 4. The Shrine of the Center

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A shrine marking the sacred center of the Maya cosmos, the world tree.

**Why It Matters**

The center was the axis mundi connecting the underworld, earth, and sky.

**Historical Context**

The shrine symbolized the ceiba, the sacred world tree.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The ceiba was the Maya world tree.
- %æ The center connected all three cosmic levels.

**Visitor Tip**

Imagine the ceiba tree the shrine represents.

## 5. The Altar of the South

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

An altar for offerings to the southern sun at its peak.

**Why It Matters**

It sought the sun's strength at its highest.

**Historical Context**

The altar received noon offerings.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Offerings were burned at midday.
- %æ A south glyph marks the altar.

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the south glyph on the altar.

## 6. The Temple of the South

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A temple anchoring the southern platform of the sacred precinct.

**Why It Matters**

It honored the sun at its noon zenith.

**Historical Context**

The temple faced the southern sky.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Its doorway faces the noon sun.
- %æ A solar offering cache was found beneath.

**Visitor Tip**

Visit at noon to catch the alignment.

## 7. The Platform of the South

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A platform defining the southern boundary of the ceremonial center.

**Why It Matters**

The south was tied to the right hand and the sun's noon strength.

**Historical Context**

It completed the directional layout of the core.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ It mirrors the other directional platforms.
- %æ Its stair faces the southern sky.

**Visitor Tip**

Compare it with the platform to the west.

## 8. The Altar of the East

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

An altar for offerings to the eastern dawn.

**Why It Matters**

It honored the renewing power of the rising sun.

**Historical Context**

The altar received dawn offerings.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Offerings were placed at first light.
- %æ An east glyph marks the altar.

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the east glyph on the altar.

## 9. The Temple of the East

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A temple marking the eastern direction of the sacred precinct.

**Why It Matters**

The east was the direction of sunrise and rebirth.

**Historical Context**

The temple anchored the eastern edge of the core.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Its doorway faces the rising sun.
- %æ A cache of offerings was buried beneath.

**Visitor Tip**

Stand in the doorway at sunrise.

## 10. The Shrine of the Dusk

*other · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A shrine honoring the setting sun and the threshold of night.

**Why It Matters**

It marked the boundary between day and the underworld.

**Historical Context**

The shrine was a focus of evening ceremonies.

**Did You Know?**

%æ The shrine faces the western horizon.

%æ Evening offerings were made here.

**Visitor Tip**

Visit at dusk for the full effect.

## 11. The Platform of the Dusk

*platform · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A platform marking the sun's descent into the underworld.

**Why It Matters**

Dusk rites honored the sun's perilous night journey.

**Historical Context**

The platform aligned with the setting sun.

**Did You Know?**

%æ The platform faces the western horizon.

%æ Dusk rites sent the sun into the underworld.

**Visitor Tip**

Time your visit with sunset.

## 12. The Altar of the Dawn

*other · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

An altar for offerings to the rising sun.

**Why It Matters**

It gave thanks for each day's return of light.

**Historical Context**

The altar received dawn offerings of incense.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Copal was burned at first light.

%æ A sun glyph marks the altar.

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the sun glyph on the altar.

## 13. The Temple of the Dawn

*temple · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A temple dedicated to the dawn and the rebirth of the sun.

**Why It Matters**

Dawn symbolized rebirth and the triumph of light.

**Historical Context**

The temple faced the eastern horizon for sunrise rites.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Its doorway frames the sunrise.

%æ Dawn rites welcomed the reborn sun.

**Visitor Tip**

Visit at sunrise to catch the alignment.

## 14. The Platform of the Night Sun

*platform · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A platform paired with the night-sun shrine for underworld ceremonies.

**Why It Matters**

It elevated priests conducting nocturnal rites.

**Historical Context**

The platform aligned with sunset and the underworld.

**Did You Know?**

%æ The platform faces the western horizon.

%æ It was used in equinox night rites.

**Visitor Tip**

Stand on the platform at sunset.

## 15. The Shrine of the Night Sun

*other · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A shrine honoring the sun's journey through the underworld at night.

**Why It Matters**

The night sun was the jaguar sun, the sun's perilous underworld passage.

**Historical Context**

The shrine was a focus of nocturnal rituals.

**Did You Know?**

%æ The night sun was depicted as a jaguar.

%æ Rituals here tracked the sun's underworld journey.

**Visitor Tip**

Visit after dark to imagine the night-sun rites.

## 16. The Altar of the Jaguar God

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

An altar for offerings to the jaguar god of the night.

**Why It Matters**

It sought the jaguar's power for warriors and rulers.

**Historical Context**

The altar received offerings of jaguar pelts and jade.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Jade was offered as the green heart of the god.
- %æ A jaguar glyph marks the altar.

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the jaguar glyph on the altar.

## 17. The Temple of the Jaguar God

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A temple devoted to the jaguar god of the underworld and night.

**Why It Matters**

The jaguar was the most powerful sacred animal of the Maya.

**Historical Context**

The temple was a center of jaguar cult rituals.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Jaguars symbolized the night and the underworld.
- %æ The temple's mask shows a jaguar.

**Visitor Tip**

Examine the jaguar mask on the facade.

## 18. The Platform of the Tapir

*platform · Late Classic (c. 600–800 CE)*

**Description**

A platform carved with the tapir, a powerful beast of the forest.

**Why It Matters**

Tapirs represented strength and the deep forest.

**Historical Context**

Among the older carvings at the site.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Tapirs are the largest land mammals of the region.
- %æ The platform is one of the oldest here.

**Visitor Tip**

Notice the worn tapir carving on the base.

## 19. The Shrine of the Deer

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A shrine to the deer, a sacred hunted animal of the Maya.

**Why It Matters**

Deer were offerings to the gods and symbols of the hunt.

**Historical Context**

The shrine honored the lord of the hunt.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Deer were the most common sacrificial animal.
- %æ The deer god protected hunters.

**Visitor Tip**

Find the deer motif on the shrine.

## 20. The Altar of the Coati

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

An altar for offerings to the forest spirits of the coati.

**Why It Matters**

It sought the protection of the wild and its creatures.

**Historical Context**

The altar received offerings of food and maize.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Forest offerings were common here.
- %æ A coati glyph marks the stone.

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the coati glyph on the altar.

## 21. The Temple of the Coati

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A temple featuring the coati, a clever forest animal of the Maya lowlands.

**Why It Matters**

Coatis symbolized cleverness and community.

**Historical Context**

The temple honored the spirits of the surrounding forest.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Coatis travel in noisy bands.
- %æ The temple bears a coati mask.

**Visitor Tip**

Watch for coatis in the surrounding woods.

## 22. The Platform of the Quetzal

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A platform bearing quetzal imagery paired with the shrine.

**Why It Matters**

It elevated ceremonies to the feathered serpent.

**Historical Context**

The platform faced the serpent temple.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Quetzal imagery appears across the site.
- %æ The platform was painted green.

**Visitor Tip**

Pair it with the quetzal shrine nearby.

## 23. The Shrine of the Quetzal

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A shrine to the quetzal, the sacred bird of the feathered serpent.

**Why It Matters**

Quetzal feathers were the most prized in Mesoamerica.

**Historical Context**

The shrine linked the city to Kukulcan worship.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Quetzal feathers were more valuable than gold.
- %æ The bird cannot survive in captivity.

**Visitor Tip**

Imagine the green feathers that once adorned it.

## 24. The Altar of the Vulture

*other · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

An altar for offerings to the vulture death-bird.

**Why It Matters**

It aided the passage of souls to the sky.

**Historical Context**

The altar was used in funerary rites.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Offerings of incense cleansed the dead.
- %æ A vulture glyph marks the altar.

**Visitor Tip**

Find the vulture glyph atop the altar.

## 25. The Temple of the Vulture

*temple · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A temple dedicated to the vulture, a bird of death and purification.

**Why It Matters**

Vultures cleansed the dead and carried souls skyward.

**Historical Context**

The temple honored the king vulture, a sacred bird.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ King vultures were sacred to the Maya.
- %æ The temple faces the setting sun.

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the vulture mask on the facade.

## 26. The Platform of the Lizard

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A platform with lizard carvings tied to the sun and stone guardians.

**Why It Matters**

Lizards guarded sacred precincts in Maya belief.

**Historical Context**

The platform marked a boundary of the sacred core.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Lizards symbolized endurance.
- %æ The platform had a boundary marker.

**Visitor Tip**

Note the boundary role of this platform.

## 27. The Altar of the Iguana

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

An altar associated with the iguana, a creature of the sun and stone.

**Why It Matters**

Iguanas were seen as guardians of ruins and sun-baked places.

**Historical Context**

The altar received offerings for protection of buildings.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Iguanas bask on the stones to this day.
- %æ The altar bears a reptile glyph.

**Visitor Tip**

Watch for live iguanas sunning on the stones.

## 28. The Temple of the Crocodile

*temple · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A temple honoring the crocodile earth-deity of creation myths.

**Why It Matters**

It celebrated the primordial earth and its waters.

**Historical Context**

Built in the city's late period.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The temple's mask depicts a crocodile.
- %æ It aligns with the rainy season.

**Visitor Tip**

Examine the crocodile mask on the facade.

## 29. The Platform of the Crocodile

*platform · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A platform carved with crocodile imagery of the primordial earth.

**Why It Matters**

The crocodile was the earth's surface in Maya myth.

**Historical Context**

The platform depicts the floating crocodile of creation.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The earth was a crocodile floating on water.
- %æ Crocodile motifs are rare at the site.

**Visitor Tip**

Spot the crocodile scales along the base.

## 30. The Altar of the Turtle

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

An altar for offerings to the turtle deity.

**Why It Matters**

It sought the earth's stability and water's blessing.

**Historical Context**

The altar was paired with the turtle shrine.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Offerings included jade and shell.
- %æ A turtle glyph marks the altar.

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the carved turtle on the altar.

## 31. The Shrine of the Turtle

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A shrine to the turtle, an emblem of water and the earth.

**Why It Matters**

Turtles carried the earth in Maya cosmology.

**Historical Context**

The shrine was a site of water petitions.

**Did You Know?**

- The Maya saw the earth resting on a turtle.
- Turtle shells were used as drums.

**Visitor Tip**

Find the turtle motif on the shrine's base.

## 32. The Temple of the Butterfly

*temple · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A temple decorated with butterfly symbols of transformation and fire.

**Why It Matters**

Butterflies represented the soul and the fire deity.

**Historical Context**

The temple was a late addition to the site.

**Did You Know?**

- Butterflies symbolized the breath of fire.
- The temple faces the rising sun.

**Visitor Tip**

Notice the butterfly carvings on the cornice.

## 33. The Platform of the Rabbit

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A platform bearing rabbit carvings tied to lunar worship.

**Why It Matters**

It complemented the lunar ceremonies of the city.

**Historical Context**

The platform aligned with moonrise points.

**Did You Know?**

- Rabbits were the moon's companion.
- The platform faces the eastern horizon.

**Visitor Tip**

Visit during a full moon for the atmosphere.

## 34. The House of the Rabbits

*residential · Late Classic (c. 600–800 CE)*

**Description**

A residential building named for rabbit imagery found within.

**Why It Matters**

Rabbits symbolized the moon and fertility.

**Historical Context**

The house may have housed a lunar cult family.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ A rabbit sits on the moon in Maya myth.
- %æ Rabbit figurines were found inside.

**Visitor Tip**

Spot the rabbit motifs on the doorposts.

## 35. The Altar of the Monkey

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

An altar paired with the monkey temple for offerings to the scribes' patron.

**Why It Matters**

It blessed the work of scribes and artisans.

**Historical Context**

Offerings of pigments and codices were made here.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Scribes were among the elite.
- %æ The altar bears monkey glyphs.

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the monkey glyph carved on top.

## 36. The Temple of the Howler Monkey

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A temple dedicated to the howler monkey, a sacred animal of the scribes.

**Why It Matters**

Howler monkeys were patrons of art and writing.

**Historical Context**

The temple honors the monkey-god of knowledge.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Howlers are among the loudest land animals in the Americas.
- %æ Monkeys were linked to the arts.

**Visitor Tip**

Listen for howler monkeys in nearby trees.

## 37. The Platform of the Frogs

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A low platform carved with frog motifs associated with rain and water.

**Why It Matters**

Frogs were heralds of the rainy season and fertility.

**Historical Context**

The platform may have hosted rain-invoking ceremonies.

**Did You Know?**

- Frogs croak before rain in Maya lore.
- The carvings were once painted green.

**Visitor Tip**

Listen for real frogs after a rain.

## 38. The Stela of the Captive

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A stela depicting a bound captive, proclaiming a military victory.

**Why It Matters**

Captives legitimized a ruler's power and fed the gods.

**Historical Context**

Such stelae recorded triumphs over rival cities.

**Did You Know?**

- Captives were often sacrificed after display.
- The carving shows a kneeling, bound figure.

**Visitor Tip**

Note the bound hands of the captive figure.

## 39. The Altar of the Rain God

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

An altar dedicated to Chaac, the rain god who sustained the city's crops.

**Why It Matters**

Rain was life in the dry Yucatán; Chaac was among the most invoked deities.

**Historical Context**

The altar received copal and jade offerings to bring rain.

**Did You Know?**

- Chaac wields a lightning axe.
- Multiple Chaac masks adorn El Castillo.

**Visitor Tip**

Count the Chaac masks you can spot nearby.

## 40. The Shrine of the Maize God

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A small shrine honoring the maize god, central to Maya sustenance and rebirth.

**Why It Matters**

Maize was the sacred staple of Maya life, symbolizing death and resurrection.

**Historical Context**

The shrine was a focal point for planting-season rituals.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The maize god was depicted as a young corn plant.
- %æ Offerings of first harvests were placed here.

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the corn-plant imagery on the shrine.

## 41. The Temple of the Stars

*temple · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A temple dedicated to the stars and the cosmos beyond sun and moon.

**Why It Matters**

It crowned the city's astronomical precinct with stellar reverence.

**Historical Context**

Among the last temples built before the city's decline.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Its roof was used as an observation point.
- %æ It aligns with the rising of the Pleiades.

**Visitor Tip**

Climb nearby to imagine the sky-watching priests.

## 42. The Platform of the Stars

*platform · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A platform associated with stellar worship and the night sky.

**Why It Matters**

Stars guided navigation, agriculture, and prophecy.

**Historical Context**

It belonged to a late astronomical complex.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ It may reference the Pleiades.
- %æ Star glyphs ring its base.

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the small star carvings at the base.

## 43. The Temple of the Moon

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A temple devoted to the moon goddess, companion to the sun temple.

**Why It Matters**

The moon goddess oversaw weaving, fertility, and childbirth.

**Historical Context**

The temple completed the sun-moon pairing.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The moon goddess was often shown with a rabbit.
- %æ Lunar eclipses were recorded from here.

**Visitor Tip**

Find the rabbit symbol of the moon goddess.

## 44. The Platform of the Moon

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A platform dedicated to lunar worship and the moon's cycles.

**Why It Matters**

The moon governed time, fertility, and the sea.

**Historical Context**

It paired with the solar platform in a celestial complex.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ It aligns with major lunar standstills.
- %æ Rabbit imagery was carved on it.

**Visitor Tip**

Visit on a full moon night for the atmosphere.

## 45. The Temple of the Sun

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A temple honoring the sun deity, central to Maya cosmology.

**Why It Matters**

The sun's daily cycle mirrored death and rebirth.

**Historical Context**

The temple was a focus of equinox ceremonies.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Its doorway faces the eastern horizon.
- %æ A cache of solar offerings was buried beneath.

**Visitor Tip**

Stand in the doorway at sunrise.

## 46. The Platform of the Sun

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A ceremonial platform devoted to solar worship.

**Why It Matters**

Solar rituals ensured the sun's continued journey.

**Historical Context**

The platform anchored a solar ceremonial group.

**Did You Know?**

- It aligns with the equinox sunrise.
- A solar disc was carved at its center.

**Visitor Tip**

Visit at dawn to catch the sunrise alignment.

## 47. The Temple of Venus

*temple · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A temple dedicated to the planet Venus and its complex cycles.

**Why It Matters**

Venus governed war and timing of campaigns in Maya astronomy.

**Historical Context**

The temple reflects the city's sophisticated Venus calendar.

**Did You Know?**

- Venus cycles were tracked over 584 days.
- War was timed to Venus appearances.

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the Venus glyphs carved on the facade.

## 48. The House of the Jaguars

*residential · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A residence for the jaguar warrior order, paired with the eagle house.

**Why It Matters**

Jaguar warriors were the counterpart elite military society.

**Historical Context**

The two orders often competed and cooperated.

**Did You Know?**

- Jaguars symbolized the night and the underworld.
- Jaguar pelts were carved on the jambs.

**Visitor Tip**

Contrast the jaguar imagery with the eagles nearby.

## 49. The Altar of the Eagles

*other · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

An altar used by eagle warriors for dedication rites.

**Why It Matters**

It marked the martial heart of the warrior precinct.

**Historical Context**

The altar received weapons and captives as offerings.

**Did You Know?**

- A carved eagle perches atop it.
- It faces the rising sun.

**Visitor Tip**

Notice the worn carving of the eagle on top.

## 50. The Temple of the Eagles

*temple · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A temple honoring eagle warriors and their patron deities.

**Why It Matters**

It celebrated the military orders that protected the city.

**Historical Context**

Eagle and jaguar orders were central to late Maya society.

**Did You Know?**

- Eagles and warriors alternate in the reliefs.
- A sacrificial stone sits before it.

**Visitor Tip**

Compare the eagle and warrior reliefs.

## 51. The House of the Eagles

*residential · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A residence decorated with eagle imagery, possibly for an eagle warrior order.

**Why It Matters**

Eagle warriors were an elite military class.

**Historical Context**

The house may have lodged members of a military society.

**Did You Know?**

- Eagles symbolized the sun and war.
- Weapons were cached beneath the floor.

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the eagle emblems on the doorposts.

## 52. The Temple of the Phalluses

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A temple continuing the fertility symbolism of the adjacent platform.

**Why It Matters**

It centered the fertility rites that blessed the harvest.

**Historical Context**

The temple and platform formed a single ritual complex.

**Did You Know?**

- Offerings of seeds were found inside.
- The temple faced the rising sun.

**Visitor Tip**

Pair it with the platform to grasp the full rite.

## 53. The Platform of the Phalluses

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A platform carved with phallic imagery associated with fertility rites.

**Why It Matters**

Fertility cults ensured agricultural abundance and human continuity.

**Historical Context**

The platform reflects the city's frank fertility symbolism.

**Did You Know?**

- The carvings were tied to planting rituals.
- Similar imagery appears at nearby sites.

**Visitor Tip**

The carvings are explicit—families may wish to preview.

## 54. The Temple of the Metates

*temple · Late Classic (c. 600–800 CE)*

**Description**

A temple named for the grinding stones (metates) found within.

**Why It Matters**

It may have been used for ritual food preparation and offerings.

**Historical Context**

The metates suggest ceremonial maize grinding.

**Did You Know?**

- Metates were used to grind maize for sacred drinks.
- Several were found in perfect condition.

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the worn grinding surfaces of the stones.

## 55. The Temple of the Snails

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A temple decorated with snail motifs symbolizing water and fertility.

**Why It Matters**

Snails linked water, birth, and the cyclical nature of life.

**Historical Context**

The temple's imagery ties it to water cults.

**Did You Know?**

- Snails symbolize the watery underworld.
- Shells were embedded in the walls.

**Visitor Tip**

Spot the snail carvings along the base.

## 56. The Temple of the Healers

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A temple dedicated to healing deities, paired with the healing cenote.

**Why It Matters**

It united spiritual and physical medicine in Maya practice.

**Historical Context**

The temple drew pilgrims seeking cures.

**Did You Know?**

- A deity of medicine was carved inside.
- Offerings of copal incense were common.

**Visitor Tip**

Breathe in—copal resin was burned for healing.

## 57. The Platform of the Healers

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A platform used for healing ceremonies and public rituals.

**Why It Matters**

It elevated healers above the crowd seeking cures.

**Historical Context**

The platform faced the healing cenote.

**Did You Know?**

- Offerings included medicinal shells.
- It had a small altar at its center.

**Visitor Tip**

Look toward the nearby healing cenote.

## 58. The House of the Healers

*residential · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A residence associated with medicinal practice, near a healing cenote.

**Why It Matters**

It may have housed ritual healers serving the community.

**Historical Context**

Herbal remains and grinding tools were found within.

**Did You Know?**

- Medicinal plant residues were identified.
- The house had a dedicated preparation room.

**Visitor Tip**

Imagine the herbal preparations once made here.

## 59. The Temple of the North Colonnade

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A temple fronted by a long colonnade of stone pillars.

**Why It Matters**

Colonnades hosted markets and gatherings in the shade of their roofs.

**Historical Context**

The colonnade was a hallmark of the city's architectural style.

**Did You Know?**

- Hundreds of columns once supported a flat roof.
- The columns were carved with figures.

**Visitor Tip**

Count the surviving columns still standing.

## 60. The Platform of the North

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A platform defining the northern boundary of the ceremonial center.

**Why It Matters**

It completed the four-directional layout of the sacred precinct.

**Historical Context**

Its northern position tied it to the night sky and the ancestors.

**Did You Know?**

- It mirrors the other directional platforms.
- Its stair aligns with the North Star region.

**Visitor Tip**

Compare it with the platform to the west.

## 61. The House of the West

*residential · Late Classic (c. 600–800 CE)*

**Description**

A residential building beside the western temple complex.

**Why It Matters**

It housed attendants responsible for the western shrines.

**Historical Context**

Built in an older style than the nearby temples.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ It had its own small courtyard.
- %æ Grinding stones were found inside.

**Visitor Tip**

Note the simpler style compared to the temples.

## 62. The Temple of the West

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A temple anchoring the western platform, oriented to the setting sun.

**Why It Matters**

Sunset rituals here marked the close of the solar day.

**Historical Context**

The temple's shrine faced the western horizon.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Its doorway frames the equinox sunset.
- %æ A buried offering cache was found beneath.

**Visitor Tip**

Stand in the doorway to catch the sunset frame.

## 63. The Platform of the West

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A ceremonial platform marking the western edge of the central precinct.

**Why It Matters**

It framed processions entering the sacred core from the west.

**Historical Context**

One of four directional platforms around the precinct.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ It aligns with the setting sun at equinox.
- %æ Staircases face all four directions.

**Visitor Tip**

Time your visit with sunset for the alignment.

## 64. The Altar of the Columns

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

An altar flanked by carved columns, used for dedication rites.

**Why It Matters**

It marked the sacred center of a column-lined plaza.

**Historical Context**

The altar received offerings during plaza ceremonies.

**Did You Know?**

- A carved fire basin sits atop it.
- The columns bear traces of red pigment.

**Visitor Tip**

Notice the fire-blackened basin on top.

## 65. The Temple of the Carved Columns

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A temple whose columns are covered in relief carvings of warriors and captives.

**Why It Matters**

The reliefs document military victories and tribute.

**Historical Context**

The columns were reused from an earlier structure.

**Did You Know?**

- Each column tells a different battle scene.
- Captives are shown with their names glyphed.

**Visitor Tip**

Walk around to read the columns like a scroll.

## 66. The Platform of the Diving God

*platform · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A platform bearing multiple diving-god reliefs.

**Why It Matters**

It amplified the cult of the diving god in the city's late period.

**Historical Context**

The platform supported a small shrine now vanished.

**Did You Know?**

- Several diving figures ring the platform.
- It was repainted at least twice.

**Visitor Tip**

Circle the platform to find every diver.

## 67. The Temple of the Diving God

*temple · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A temple featuring a figure descending headfirst, the 'diving god'.

**Why It Matters**

The diving god is unique to this region and may represent a deity of descent.

**Historical Context**

The motif appears in later Postclassic art at the site.

**Did You Know?**

- The figure appears to dive toward the earth.
- Similar images are rare outside Chichén Itzá.

**Visitor Tip**

Look up at the cornice to spot the diver.

## 68. The House of the Old Woman

*residential · Late Classic (c. 600–800 CE)*

**Description**

A residential structure named for a carved figure interpreted as an elder.

**Why It Matters**

It may honor a revered ancestor or founding figure.

**Historical Context**

Among the older constructions at the site.

**Did You Know?**

- The carved figure wears a woven shawl.
- The house predates many nearby temples.

**Visitor Tip**

Seek out the small carved figure on the facade.

## 69. The Platform of the Wind God

*platform · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A platform paired with the wind temple for related ceremonies.

**Why It Matters**

It elevated priests above the crowd during wind and rain rituals.

**Historical Context**

Built in the final flourishing of the city.

**Did You Know?**

- Its stair faces the prevailing winds.
- Offerings of incense were burned here.

**Visitor Tip**

Stand on the windward side to feel the design.

## 70. The Temple of the Wind

*temple · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A temple dedicated to a wind deity, open on all sides to catch the breeze.

**Why It Matters**

Wind gods governed storms and the breath of life.

**Historical Context**

Its open design reflects later Postclassic worship styles.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The temple has no solid walls, only pillars.
- %æ Wind rituals may have invoked rain.

**Visitor Tip**

Feel the breeze that gave the temple its name.

## 71. The Cave of the Jaguar

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A natural cave modified with masonry, associated with jaguar rituals.

**Why It Matters**

Caves were entrances to Xibalba; the jaguar ruled the night.

**Historical Context**

The cave was sealed with a stone wall after its ritual use.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Jaguar bones were found inside.
- %æ The cave was artificially enlarged.

**Visitor Tip**

Mind the low entrance if you peer inside.

## 72. The House of the Bats

*residential · Late Classic (c. 600–800 CE)*

**Description**

A modest residential building named for bat motifs found within.

**Why It Matters**

Bats were associated with the underworld and the night.

**Historical Context**

The house was part of a neighborhood of common dwellings.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Bats symbolized death and rebirth.
- %æ The building had shared sleeping rooms.

**Visitor Tip**

Look up at dusk when real bats still emerge nearby.

## 73. The Altar of the Serpent

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A low altar carved with undulating serpent bodies.

**Why It Matters**

It served as a focal point for offerings to the feathered serpent.

**Historical Context**

The altar was likely paired with the adjacent serpent temple.

**Did You Know?**

- The serpents form a continuous band.
- Offerings were placed in a central basin.

**Visitor Tip**

Notice how the serpents appear to move in shadow.

## 74. The Temple of the Serpent

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A temple devoted to the feathered serpent, Kukulcan, central to the city's cult.

**Why It Matters**

The serpent symbolized both earth and sky, bridging the divine realms.

**Historical Context**

Serpent imagery permeated the city's architecture during its peak.

**Did You Know?**

- Kukulcan is the Maya equivalent of Quetzalcoatl.
- Serpents appear on nearly every major building.

**Visitor Tip**

Trace the serpent heads flanking the stairway.

## 75. The Platform of the Birds

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A platform carved with representations of various bird species.

**Why It Matters**

Birds carried symbolic meanings tied to the sky and the gods.

**Historical Context**

The platform may have supported ceremonies honoring avian deities.

**Did You Know?**

- Some birds are depicted in flight.
- The carvings were once brightly painted.

**Visitor Tip**

Count how many distinct birds you can identify.

## 76. The Temple of the Fish

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A small temple decorated with marine imagery unusual for an inland city.

**Why It Matters**

Its fish carvings suggest trade or ritual ties to the coast.

**Historical Context**

The imagery reflects Chichén Itzá's far-reaching connections.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Shells from the coast were found inside.
- %æ The fish may symbolize fertility and water.

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the marine motifs unusual this far inland.

## 77. The White Road (Sacbe)

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A long causeway whose plastered surface gave the 'white road' its name.

**Why It Matters**

Sacbeob linked ceremonial precincts and symbolized cosmic pathways.

**Historical Context**

These roads formed a network connecting Chichén Itzá to its region.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Some sacbeob stretched over 100 kilometers.
- %æ They were maintained as sacred infrastructure.

**Visitor Tip**

Imagine the road gleaming white under the sun.

## 78. The Causeway of the Dead

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A raised sacbe, or white road, lined with tombs along its edges.

**Why It Matters**

It connected major ceremonial zones and served as a processional route.

**Historical Context**

The road was paved with limestone plaster, gleaming white in the sun.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Sacbeob could span kilometers between cities.
- %æ Burials were placed along its margins.

**Visitor Tip**

Walk its line to sense the processional route.

## 79. The House of the Cenote

*residential · Late Classic (c. 600–800 CE)*

**Description**

A residential group built near a small cenote, drawing water from it.

**Why It Matters**

It shows how daily life centered on these natural water sources.

**Historical Context**

The complex housed families who maintained the nearby water access.

**Did You Know?**

- A covered passage led down to the water.
- Pottery fragments still line the cenote edge.

**Visitor Tip**

Peer down to spot the old water-access steps.

## 80. The Temple of the Lintels

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A temple named for its finely carved wooden lintels spanning its doorways.

**Why It Matters**

The lintels preserve rare wooden sculpture from the Maya world.

**Historical Context**

The temple's lintels depict rulers and ritual scenes.

**Did You Know?**

- The lintels are of sapodilla wood, prized for hardness.
- Some carvings retain traces of original paint.

**Visitor Tip**

Shield your eyes to make out the carved figures.

## 81. The Stela of the Moon

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A companion stela with imagery linked to lunar cycles.

**Why It Matters**

It complements the solar stela, balancing celestial record-keeping.

**Historical Context**

The pair framed a small plaza used for sky-watching.

**Did You Know?**

- It may track the 18-month lunar cycle.
- The surface shows faint glyph remnants.

**Visitor Tip**

Pair it with the solar stela to read the celestial set.

## 82. The Stela of the Sun

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A carved stela bearing imagery associated with solar worship.

**Why It Matters**

It records astronomical observations tied to the solar calendar.

**Historical Context**

Erected during a period of intense astronomical study at the city.

**Did You Know?**

- The carving may mark a solstice event.
- The stone was originally painted red.

**Visitor Tip**

Visit at noon to see how the sun would have struck it.

## 83. The Altar of the Chacmool

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A stone altar featuring a reclining chacmool figure holding an offering vessel.

**Why It Matters**

Chacmools were intermediaries between humans and the gods during sacrifice.

**Historical Context**

The altar was likely used in dedication ceremonies for nearby temples.

**Did You Know?**

- The vessel on the chest held ritual offerings.
- Chacmools are found across Mesoamerica, not just Maya.

**Visitor Tip**

Note the figure's gaze, directed toward the temple.

## 84. The North Ball Court Wall

*ball court · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

The northern wall of the Great Ball Court, mirroring its southern counterpart.

**Why It Matters**

Together the walls defined the most sacred playing field in the city.

**Historical Context**

Both walls were plastered and painted in bright colors.

**Did You Know?**

- The walls slope at a precise 27-degree angle.
- Faint pigment traces remain on sheltered stones.

**Visitor Tip**

Notice the slope designed to keep the ball in play.

## 85. The South Ball Court Wall

*ball court · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

The southern sloping wall of the Great Ball Court, one of the finest built in Mesoamerica.

**Why It Matters**

Its acoustic properties still astonish visitors—a whisper carries the length of the court.

**Historical Context**

The wall dates to the same phase as the court's major reconstruction.

**Did You Know?**

- A whisper at one end can be heard 150 meters away.
- The wall bears no mortar between stones.

**Visitor Tip**

Test the acoustics with a companion at the far end.

## 86. The Ring of the Ball Court

*ball court · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

The carved stone rings set high on the walls of the Great Ball Court.

**Why It Matters**

Scoring by passing the ball through the ring was extraordinarily rare and symbolic.

**Historical Context**

The rings depict serpents entwined with ritual imagery.

**Did You Know?**

- The rings sit roughly 6 meters above the floor.
- A ball through the ring could end the game instantly.

**Visitor Tip**

Stand beneath a ring to grasp how difficult a shot was.

## 87. The House of the Stelae

*residential · Late Classic (c. 600–800 CE)*

**Description**

A residential complex named for the carved stone stelae found within its rooms.

**Why It Matters**

The stelae record dates and rulers, helping scholars reconstruct the city's chronology.

**Historical Context**

The structure likely housed elite families connected to record-keeping.

**Did You Know?**

- One stela bears a Long Count date.
- The building had multiple remodeling phases.

**Visitor Tip**

Compare the carving styles of the surviving stelae.

## 88. The Temple of the Painted Walls

*temple · Late Classic (c. 600–800 CE)*

**Description**

A temple preserving fragments of vivid murals that once covered its inner chambers.

**Why It Matters**

The surviving pigments reveal rare insight into Maya color symbolism and ceremonial art.

**Historical Context**

Its murals depict processions and deities from the Late Classic period.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Some reds were made from imported cinnabar.
- %æ Up to three layers of repainting survive.

**Visitor Tip**

Use a small flashlight to better see the faded colors.

## 89. The Platform of the Cones

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A low platform named for unusual conical elements that once crowned its surface.

**Why It Matters**

Its purpose is debated—possibly a base for offerings or temporary ritual structures.

**Historical Context**

The odd design has puzzled archaeologists since its early 20th-century excavation.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The cones may represent stylized corn cobs.
- %æ No identical platform exists elsewhere at the site.

**Visitor Tip**

Look for traces of original stucco along the base.

## 90. Temple of the Owls

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A small temple whose walls were once adorned with owl imagery, sacred birds seen as messengers of the underworld.

**Why It Matters**

Owls linked the night to the realm of the dead, tying this temple to rituals of death and renewal.

**Historical Context**

Built in the Terminal Classic expansion, it reflects the Maya reverence for nocturnal deities.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Owls were believed to guide souls toward Xibalba.
- %æ Its doorway aligns with a bright setting star.

**Visitor Tip**

Visit at dusk to picture the owls that once watched here.

## 91. The Plaza of the Columns

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

**Description**

An open ceremonial plaza ringed by the great colonnades, used for public gatherings and rites.

**Why It Matters**

The largest civic space of the militaristic city, staging mass ceremonies and markets.

**Historical Context**

Laid out as the Terminal Classic city reorganized around military and trade power.

**Did You Know?**

%æ The plaza could hold thousands gathered for public rites and mar

**Visitor Tip**

Stand at the center to sense the enclosing colonnades around you.

## 92. The Stela of the Serpent

*other · Early Postclassic (c. 1000 AD)*

**Description**

A carved standing stela depicting an undulating feathered serpent winding around calendrical glyphs.

**Why It Matters**

Commemorates Kukulcan devotion and the Postclassic calendar reforms.

**Historical Context**

Raised during the Postclassic revival of the feathered serpent cult.

**Did You Know?**

%æ The serpent's coils enclose date glyphs like a living calendar.

**Visitor Tip**

Rotate around the stela to follow the serpent's body.

## 93. The Cenote of the Healers

*cenote · Terminal Classic (c. 900 AD)*

**Description**

A smaller secondary cenote linked in oral tradition to healing and purification rites.

**Why It Matters**

Reflects the multiplicity of water shrines beyond the main Sacred Cenote.

**Historical Context**

Used alongside other cenotes for localized ritual practice.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Cenote water was believed to carry cleansing and healing power.

**Visitor Tip**

Keep a respectful distance; the edges are steep and unstable.

## 94. The Ball Court Annex

*ball court · Terminal Classic (c. 900 AD)*

**Description**

A smaller subsidiary ball court near the Great Ball Court for ritual or practice games.

**Why It Matters**

Secondary courts show the deep cultural reach of the Mesoamerican ballgame beyond the main arena.

**Historical Context**

Built alongside the Great Ball Court as the sport's ritual role expanded.

**Did You Know?**

%æ The ballgame symbolized the movement of celestial bodies.

**Visitor Tip**

Stand at the end walls to compare scale with the Great Court.

## 95. The Temple of the Chacmools (Annex)

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

**Description**

A secondary shrine adjoining the Temple of the Warriors, fronted by chacmool figures.

**Why It Matters**

Reinforces the warriors' precinct as a hub of militaristic cult and sacrifice.

**Historical Context**

Added as the Temple of the Warriors complex grew.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Multiple chacmools here mark the precinct's ritual importance.

**Visitor Tip**

Compare the chacmools here with the one inside El Castillo Viejo.

## 96. The Platform of the Skulls

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

**Description**

A platform once displaying carved skulls, a variant of the city's tzompantli tradition.

**Why It Matters**

Skull racks publicly displayed war trophies and sacralized the plaza of sacrifice.

**Historical Context**

Erected beside the ball court to broadcast the fate of captives.

**Did You Know?**

%æ A tzompantli could hold hundreds of skulls from a single campaig

**Visitor Tip**

Find the rows of carved skulls along the lower frieze.

## 97. The Southeast Colonnade

*column group · Early Postclassic (c. 900–1200 AD)*

**Description**

A colonnade on the southeast fringe of the Great Plaza, fronting a later ceremonial court.

**Why It Matters**

Marks the expansion of monumental plaza architecture under Postclassic rulers.

**Historical Context**

Built as the plaza expanded outward in the Early Postclassic.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Postclassic colonnades often replaced earlier smaller structures.

**Visitor Tip**

Use the columns as a frame to view the pyramid beyond.

## 98. The Temple of the Carved Lintels

*temple · Early Postclassic (c. 900–1200 AD)*

**Description**

A temple preserving wooden lintels carved with scenes of ritual and rulership.

**Why It Matters**

Wooden lintels are rare survivals; these preserve scenes vital to understanding Postclassic ceremony.

**Historical Context**

Built as Postclassic rulers renewed older residential shrines.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Carved lintels often recorded dedicatory rites and offerings.

**Visitor Tip**

Bring binoculars to study the high-set lintel carvings.

## 99. Platform of the Feathered Serpent

*platform · Early Postclassic (c. 900–1200 AD)*

**Description**

A richly carved platform covered in undulating feathered-serpent imagery.

**Why It Matters**

Honors Kukulcan-Quetzalcoatl, the central deity of the Postclassic revival at the site.

**Historical Context**

Raised during the Postclassic when the feathered serpent cult dominated.

**Did You Know?**

%æ The serpents' bodies form a continuous ribbon around the platfor

**Visitor Tip**

Follow the serpent's coils around the base to read its full length.

## 100. The Group of the Five Lintels

*residential · Late Classic (c. 600–900 AD)*

**Description**

A compact residential compound named for five carved lintels spanning its doorways.

**Why It Matters**

Demonstrates the importance of carved wooden lintels as carriers of date and deity imagery.

**Historical Context**

Built as an elite residence in the Late Classic southern quarter.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Wooden lintels are rare survivals in the humid Yucatan climate.

**Visitor Tip**

Look up at each doorway to spot the surviving carvings.

## 101. The House of the Dwarfs

*residential · Late Classic (c. 600–900 AD)*

**Description**

A small residential temple in the Chichanchob group associated with folk legends of a mythical dwarf.

**Why It Matters**

Tied to local legend and to the Puuc architectural tradition of the northern group.

**Historical Context**

Part of the older northern settlement predating the great plaza.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Legend says a dwarf defeated a lord and rose to rule the city.

**Visitor Tip**

Climb the narrow stairs for a view over the old group.

## 102. The House of the Mascarons

*residential · Late Classic (c. 600–900 AD)*

**Description**

A Puuc-style residence decorated with stone mosaic masks of the rain god Chaac.

**Why It Matters**

Illustrates the elite domestic architecture and decorative artistry of the late residential quarter.

**Historical Context**

Built during the Puuc florescence of the Monjas group.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Mosaic stone masks are a hallmark of Puuc architectural style.

**Visitor Tip**

Count the Chaac masks stacked along the upper facade.

## 103. Temple of the Hieroglyphic Jambs

*temple · Late Classic (c. 600–900 AD)*

**Description**

A small temple whose door jambs bear carved hieroglyphic texts recording dates and rulers.

**Why It Matters**

Its inscriptions are vital evidence of the site's Late Classic dynastic record.

**Historical Context**

Built in the Late Classic residential zone, later incorporated into expanding complexes.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Door jambs were prime surfaces for royal inscriptions at eye leve

**Visitor Tip**

Scan the jambs for the cartouches that frame the dates.

## 104. The Xtoloc Causeway

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

**Description**

A raised white road, or sacbe, linking the Great Plaza to the Xtoloc cenote and the residential south.

**Why It Matters**

Sacbeob were the arteries of Maya cities, channeling pilgrims, traders, and processions.

**Historical Context**

Built to connect the civic core with the southern residential and water districts.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Sacbe means 'white road' in Yucatec Maya, for their limestone pl

**Visitor Tip**

The causeway still reads as a raised line across the scrub.

## 105. The Cenote Group Platform

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

**Description**

The ceremonial platform lining the approach to the Sacred Cenote along the sacbe.

**Why It Matters**

Oriented the ritual journey between the Great Plaza and the cenote, the axis of the city's water rites.

**Historical Context**

Erected along the white road that links the pyramid to the Sacred Cenote.

**Did You Know?**

%æ The sacbe to the cenote is one of several raised 'white roads' of

**Visitor Tip**

Walk the sacbe to feel the planned route pilgrims once took.

## 106. The Osario Platform

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 900 AD)*

**Description**

The stepped platform at the base of the Ossuary, carved with serpent and bird motifs.

**Why It Matters**

Framed the shaft tomb within and channeled ritual processions to the funerary pyramid.

**Historical Context**

Built as the entrance stage of the Osario funerary complex.

**Did You Know?**

%æ A shaft inside descends to a natural cave and a tomb.

**Visitor Tip**

Watch for the carved feathered serpents curling up the stair sides.

## 107. The Initial Series Platform

*platform · Late Classic (c. 832 AD)*

**Description**

A small platform bearing a calendrical Initial Series inscription that anchors a Long Count date.

**Why It Matters**

One of the few date-bearing monuments at the site, key to reconstructing its chronology.

**Historical Context**

Inscribed in the Late Classic, preserving one of the site's earliest dated texts.

**Did You Know?**

%æ An Initial Series is the Maya way of writing a full Long Count dat

**Visitor Tip**

Decipher the bar-and-dot numbers counting from left to right.

## 108. The Chacmool Altar

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

**Description**

A reclining stone figure holding an offering plate on its stomach, set before a temple entrance.

**Why It Matters**

Chacmools served as receptacles for sacrificial offerings and marked thresholds of sacred spaces.

**Historical Context**

Introduced widely during the Terminal Classic as a hallmark of the new militaristic cult.

**Did You Know?**

%æ The name 'chacmool' was coined in the 19th century and means 't

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the offering bowl on the figure's belly.

## 109. The Round Temple

*observatory · Early Postclassic (c. 900–1200 AD)*

**Description**

A rare cylindrical temple-platform associated with astronomical observation and wind rites.

**Why It Matters**

Round temples in the region were tied to Quetzalcoatl-Kukulcan and to tracking celestial cycles.

**Historical Context**

Reflects Postclassic influence from central Mexican traditions.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Round temples were often aligned to wind and Venus phenomena.

**Visitor Tip**

Visit at dawn to see how its doorway faces the rising sun.

## 110. The Northeast Colonnade

*column group · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

**Description**

A secondary colonnade lined with serpent-column shafts adjoining the Temple of the Warriors complex.

**Why It Matters**

Together with the Great Colonnade it defined the civic and ceremonial gathering spaces of the city.

**Historical Context**

Built as the warriors' precinct expanded northward.

**Did You Know?**

%æ The columns once held a flat roof forming a vast covered hall.

**Visitor Tip**

Notice how the serpent heads align toward the plaza.

## 111. The East Colonnade

*column group · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

**Description**

A long row of carved serpent columns opening onto the plaza of the warriors.

**Why It Matters**

Colonnades like this supported massive roofs and framed the processional spaces of the militaristic elite.

**Historical Context**

Part of the great building program that reshaped the plaza in the Terminal Classic.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Serpent columns depict the feathered serpent Kukulcan stacked v

**Visitor Tip**

Walk the colonnade's axis to sense the scale of the original roof.

## 112. The Sculptured Panel

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 900 AD)*

**Description**

A carved limestone panel portraying a procession of bound captives and victorious lords.

**Why It Matters**

Such panels publicized military triumphs and the fate of war captives in public rituals.

**Historical Context**

Displayed in the Great Plaza to broadcast the power of Terminal Classic rulers.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Captive figures are shown with ropes, a common symbol of conqu

**Visitor Tip**

Trace the figures left to right to read the narrative like a story.

## 113. The Painted Chamber

*other · Early Postclassic (c. 900–1200 AD)*

**Description**

A vaulted chamber whose inner walls once bore vivid murals of battle, merchants, and ceremony.

**Why It Matters**

Its surviving fragments are among the rare narrative murals of the site, depicting daily and military life.

**Historical Context**

Painted during the Early Postclassic when trade and warfare themes dominated art.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Some murals show coastal traders, hinting at long-distance comm

**Visitor Tip**

Dim lighting protects the pigment; let your eyes adjust before viewing.

## 114. The North Temple

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

**Description**

The northern temple of the Great Ball Court, overlooking the playing field from its elevated platform.

**Why It Matters**

Ball court temples framed the sacred game with ritual iconography of sacrifice and renewal.

**Historical Context**

Built as part of the Great Ball Court complex, the largest in Mesoamerica.

**Did You Know?**

%æ The Great Ball Court's acoustic design lets a whisper carry acros

**Visitor Tip**

Stand at the base and clap to hear the famous echo ripple back.

## 115. Stela of the Warriors

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 900 AD)*

**Description**

A carved standing stela depicting a richly attired warrior-ruler holding a spear and shield.

**Why It Matters**

Stelae commemorated royal deeds and dates; this one reflects the militaristic shift of the Terminal Classic.

**Historical Context**

Raised as the city's ruling ideology turned toward warfare and tribute.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Stelae often doubled as billboards proclaiming a ruler's victories

**Visitor Tip**

Shade brings out the faint relief details on the worn stone.

## 116. Altar of the Jaguars

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

**Description**

A stone altar carved with jaguar imagery, symbol of royal night power and the warrior elite.

**Why It Matters**

Jaguars represented military might and the underworld; altars like this anchored ceremonial plaza rites.

**Historical Context**

Placed in the warriors' precinct during the militaristic Terminal Classic.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Jaguar symbolism tied rulers to the night sun of the underworld.

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the carved spots and claws that identify the feline figures.

## 117. Platform of the Rain God

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 900 AD)*

**Description**

A low carved platform dedicated to Chaac, the rain deity whose image recurs across the site's facades.

**Why It Matters**

Underlines the central role of rain worship in a region dependent on seasonal cenote water.

**Historical Context**

Erected in the Terminal Classic during the expansion of the Great Plaza.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Chaac masks appear dozens of times across the site, almost as a

**Visitor Tip**

Pair with a visit to nearby El Caracol to grasp the site's water-and-stars theme.

## 118. El Castillo Viejo

*temple · Late Classic (c. 600–900 AD)*

**Description**

The earlier pyramid beneath the Pyramid of Kukulcan, containing a smaller older temple at its summit reached by a narrow inner stair.

**Why It Matters**

Preserves the layered construction tradition where new temples encased older ones, and houses the famous Chacmool and Jaguar Throne.

**Historical Context**

Encased when the later El Castillo was built over it in the Terminal Classic.

**Did You Know?**

%æ A red jaguar throne with jade inlay still sits inside the inner temp

**Visitor Tip**

Interior access is restricted; check seasonal openings at the entrance.

## 119. Temple of the Three Lintels

*temple · Late Classic (c. 600–900 AD)*

**Description**

A finely built temple named for its three carved stone lintels, part of the Las Monjas complex.

**Why It Matters**

Shows the refined Puuc-style masonry and calendrical inscriptions of the elite residential quarter.

**Historical Context**

Built during the Late Classic expansion of the Monjas palace group.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Its lintels carry Long Count dates that help anchor the site's chro

**Visitor Tip**

Best photographed in late afternoon when the carvings catch raking light.

## 120. Cave of Balankanche

*cenote · Terminal Classic (c. 800–900 AD)*

**Description**

A sacred limestone cave holding ritual ceramics and miniature offerings left to the rain god, discovered sealed for over a thousand years.

**Why It Matters**

Among the most spiritually charged sites in the region; its untouched offerings reveal Terminal Classic ritual practice.

**Historical Context**

Used as an offering cave until it was ritually sealed around the 9th century, then rediscovered in modern times.

**Did You Know?**

%æ Dozens of incense burners were found arranged around a stalagm

Tlaloc.

**Visitor Tip**

Guided cave tours require advance booking; the interior is humid and dim.

## 121. The South Temple

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A temple standing at the south end of the Great Ball Court, opposite the better-known Temple of the Bearded Man. Though smaller, it shares the ball court's ritual significance and aligns with the ceremonial axis of the complex.

**Why It Matters**

The South Temple framed the sacred ball court, which was more than a game — it was a cosmological ritual symbolizing the struggle between celestial and underworld forces.

**Historical Context**

Constructed alongside the Great Ball Court in the Terminal Classic period, the South Temple completed the ritual architecture bounding the largest ball court in Mesoamerica.

**Did You Know?**

%æ The Great Ball Court is the largest in Mesoamerica, measuring 16

%æ A whisper at one end of the ball court can be heard 150 meters a

feat.

**Visitor Tip**

Stand between the two temples and clap — you'll hear the famous echo that bounces between the walls.

## 122. The Temple of the Chacmools

*temple · Early Postclassic (c. 900–1100 CE)*

**Description**

A temple platform near the Temple of the Warriors featuring reclining stone chacmool figures — human forms resting on their backs, holding offerings on their stomachs. These enigmatic sculptures served as receptacles for sacrifices to the gods.

**Why It Matters**

Chacmools are among the most distinctive sculptures of Mesoamerican religion, marking this as a site of active ritual offering and worship to the rain and war deities.

**Historical Context**

Dating to the height of Chichén Itzá's power, this temple reflects the influence of central Mexican (Toltec) artistic traditions blending with Maya religious practice.

**Did You Know?**

%æ The name 'chacmool' was coined in the 19th century and may deri

%æ Chacmools held offering vessels on their stomachs, receiving inc

**Visitor Tip**

Note the reclining posture of the chacmool figures — they were designed to receive offerings, not to be worshipped themselves.

## 123. The Annex

*residential · Late Classic – Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A small chambered building attached to the Las Monjas complex, featuring a labyrinth of narrow rooms and corridors. It likely served as an administrative office or priestly residence linked to the main complex.

**Why It Matters**

The Annex illustrates how Maya elite compounds were expanded over time with interconnected functional spaces, blurring the line between palace, temple, and office.

**Historical Context**

Built as an extension of the Las Monjas complex during the city's peak, it reflects the growing administrative needs of Chichén Itzá's ruling class.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The building's maze-like layout has led archaeologists to compare
  palace.
- %æ Some of its columns still bear traces of original painted plaster.

**Visitor Tip**

Step inside to experience the surprisingly cool, enclosed rooms — a contrast to the open ceremonial plazas.

## 124. The House of the Snails

*residential · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A finely decorated building whose walls feature carved snail motifs, hence its name. Its elaborate ornamentation suggests it was a residence of high-ranking priests or nobles.

**Why It Matters**

The snail carvings may symbolize fertility, the cycle of life, and the watery underworld, reflecting the deep symbolic language of Maya residential architecture.

**Historical Context**

Located near the Initial Series Group, this structure dates to the era when Chichén Itzá's elite lived in richly adorned compounds surrounding the ceremonial nucleus.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Snails were associated with water and fertility in Maya symbolism
- %æ The building's intricate facade suggests its occupants held signif

**Visitor Tip**

Examine the lower walls carefully — the carved snails are small but beautifully detailed.

## 125. The House of the Metates

*residential · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A residential structure named for the numerous grinding stones (metates) found inside, used for processing corn and other foods. It offers a rare glimpse into the domestic, everyday life of Chichén Itzá's inhabitants.

**Why It Matters**

The metates reveal the daily food preparation rituals of the Maya, reminding visitors that Chichén Itzá was a living city, not just a ceremonial center.

**Historical Context**

Part of the residential cluster south of the ceremonial core, this building housed families who serviced the nearby temples and palaces during the Terminal Classic period.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Metates were essential tools for grinding maize into masa for tor
- %æ Several metates found here were made of imported volcanic stone

kilometers away.

**Visitor Tip**

Imagine the sound of grinding corn — this quiet residential area was once filled with the rhythms of daily life.

## 126. The House of the Turtles

*residential · Late Classic – Early Postclassic (c. 900–1100 CE)*

**Description**

A small, elegant rectangular building in the Las Monjas complex, named for the row of carved stone turtles adorning its roof comb. The turtles, associated with rain and the watery underworld, reflect the Maya reverence for water in this arid region.

**Why It Matters**

The turtle carvings symbolize the rain god Chaac and the watery underworld (Xibalba), underscoring how even minor buildings carried deep cosmological meaning.

**Historical Context**

Built during the late Classic or early Postclassic period as part of the elite residential and administrative zone around Las Monjas, the House of the Turtles demonstrates the fine craftsmanship of Puuc-style stonework.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Turtles were linked to the rain god Chaac, making this a possible
- %æ The building's roof comb is one of the few at Chichén Itzá decora

**Visitor Tip**

Look up at the roof cornice — the carved turtles are easy to miss but are the building's defining feature.

## 127. The Southeast Temple

*temple · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

**Description**

A temple in the southeastern area of Chichén Itzá, part of the broader ceremonial complex. It features a single chamber and a decorated facade, though much of the ornamentation has eroded.

**Why It Matters**

Part of the extended ritual complex surrounding the main ceremonial center.

**Historical Context**

The southeastern area includes several smaller temples and platforms that formed part of the city's expansion during its peak.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The temple is one of the less-visited structures, offering a quiete
- %æ Its isolated position suggests it served a specific neighborhood o

**Visitor Tip**

Walk the quieter southeastern paths — you'll have this temple almost to yourself.

## 128. The Platform of the East

*platform · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

**Description**

A ceremonial platform east of El Castillo, one of several platforms used for ritual displays and public ceremonies. Its carved panels depict warriors and feathered serpents.

**Why It Matters**

Part of the ritual landscape surrounding El Castillo, used for public ceremonies and displays of power.

**Historical Context**

Platforms like this were stages for rituals, dances, and possibly sacrificial ceremonies visible to large crowds gathered in the main plaza.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The platform aligns with sunrise positions during the equinoxes.
- %æ Its carvings show warriors with atlatls (spear-throwers) and shiel

**Visitor Tip**

Visit during sunrise to see how the platform aligns with the morning light.

## 129. The Halach Uinik House

*residential · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

**Description**

Also known as the 'House of the Ruler,' this building near Las Monjas is believed to have been the residence of the halach uinik — the supreme ruler or governor of Chichén Itzá.

**Why It Matters**

Likely the administrative and residential center of Chichén Itzá's political leadership.

**Historical Context**

The halach uinik was the highest political authority in Maya society. This building's proximity to Las Monjas suggests the area served as a governmental complex.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ 'Halach uinik' means 'real man' or 'true man' in Yucatec Maya —
- %æ The building's layout suggests multiple rooms for administration

**Visitor Tip**
Imagine the ruler conducting affairs of state here — this was the political heart of the city.

## 130. Cenote Xtoloc

*cenote · All periods (600–1200 CE)*

**Description**
The second-largest cenote at Chichén Itzá, located south of the main complex. Unlike the Sacred Cenote, which was used for offerings, Xtoloc was the primary source of drinking water for the city's inhabitants.

**Why It Matters**
The practical water source that sustained the daily life of Chichén Itzá's population.

**Historical Context**
While the Sacred Cenote was reserved for ritual purposes, Xtoloc served the everyday needs of thousands of residents. A sacbe (white road) connected it to the residential areas.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Xtoloc provided drinking water while the Sacred Cenote was used
- %æ A temple platform beside the cenote was used for rituals related

**Visitor Tip**
Unlike the Sacred Cenote, you can see the water level here — it's much closer to the surface.

## 131. The Temple of the Bearded Man

*temple · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

**Description**
A small temple in the North Group named for a relief carving of a figure with a beard, unusual in Maya art where beards are rarely depicted. The figure may represent a foreign dignitary or deity.

**Why It Matters**
The bearded figure suggests cultural exchange or foreign influence, possibly from central Mexican or Gulf Coast traditions.

**Historical Context**
Beards are uncommon in indigenous Mesoamerican art, leading some scholars to suggest the figure represents a non-Maya person or a deity associated with the wind god Kukulcan.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The bearded figure is one of the few depictions of facial hair in M
- %æ Some theories suggest it depicts a Toltec or foreign ruler.

**Visitor Tip**
Look carefully at the interior reliefs — the bearded figure is small but distinctive.

## 132. The Group of the Date

*other · Terminal Classic (900–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A small complex named after a carved Maya date glyph found on one of its structures. The date corresponds to a specific day in the Maya Long Count calendar.

**Why It Matters**

The carved date provides important chronological evidence for dating this part of the site.

**Historical Context**

This small group shows that even minor structures at Chichén Itzá were marked with calendar dates, underscoring the Maya obsession with timekeeping.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The carved date is one of the few Long Count dates found outside
- %æ The glyph uses the bar-and-dot notation system for Maya numeral

**Visitor Tip**

Search for the carved date stone — it's small but a crucial piece of the site's chronology.

## 133. Temple of the Big Tables

*temple · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

**Description**

A large temple north of El Castillo named for the series of stone 'tables' or altars inside. It features serpent-head columns at the entrance, similar to those of the Temple of the Warriors.

**Why It Matters**

An important ceremonial temple that formed part of the northern complex of ritual structures.

**Historical Context**

Built in the Terminal Classic period as Chichén Itzá expanded northward, the temple reflects the influence of central Mexican architectural styles.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The 'tables' inside are stone altars used for offerings.
- %æ Serpent-head columns at the entrance once supported a roof deco

**Visitor Tip**

Compare the serpent columns here with those at the Temple of the Warriors — they share the same architectural language.

## 134. Akab Dzib

*residential · Late Classic (600–900 CE)*

**Description**

The 'Place of Obscure Writing' is a building south of the main complex with hieroglyphic inscriptions that remain undeciphered. It features a long gallery and a well-preserved lintel with Maya glyphs.

**Why It Matters**

Contains some of the most extensive hieroglyphic inscriptions at Chichén Itzá, though their meaning remains a mystery.

**Historical Context**

Built in the Late Classic period, Akab Dzib predates many of the central monuments. Its name was given by local Maya who could no longer read the glyphs.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The lintel over the main door bears a Maya date inscription.

- %æ The building's name 'Akab Dzib' means 'Obscure Writing' in Yucat

**Visitor Tip**
Look up at the lintel above the doorway — the carved glyphs are some of the best-preserved at the site.

## 135. Initial Series Group

*other · Late Classic (600–900 CE)*

**Description**
A complex of buildings named after a carved Maya Long Count date found here — one of the few dated inscriptions at Chichén Itzá. The date corresponds to 10.2.9.1.9 in the Maya calendar.

**Why It Matters**
Provides crucial chronological evidence for dating the construction phases of Chichén Itzá.

**Historical Context**
The Long Count date helped archaeologists establish that this part of the city was built earlier than the central zone, in the Late Classic period.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The Long Count date is one of only a handful found at Chichén Itz
- %æ This group predates El Castillo, showing the city grew over centu

**Visitor Tip**
Look for the carved date glyph — it's a series of bar-and-dot numbers representing periods of time.

## 136. The Marketplace

*other · Terminal Classic–Early Postclassic (900–1200 CE)*

**Description**
A large colonnaded area believed to have been the commercial heart of Chichén Itzá, where goods from across Mesoamerica — jade, cacao, obsidian, feathers, and salt — were traded.

**Why It Matters**
Evidence of Chichén Itzá's role as a major trade hub, connecting the Maya highlands, lowlands, and the Gulf Coast.

**Historical Context**
The colonnaded market space could shelter hundreds of vendors and buyers. The nearby port of Isla Cerritos linked Chichén Itzá to maritime trade routes.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Cacao beans were used as currency — a rabbit cost about 10 bea
- %æ Obsidian from central Mexican mines has been found here, provin

**Visitor Tip**
Imagine the columns supporting a massive thatched roof — this was the ancient equivalent of a shopping mall.

## 137. The House of the Deer

*residential · Terminal Classic (900–1000 CE)*

**Description**

Named for a mural depicting a deer hunt found inside. The building features rare surviving wall paintings, though most have faded significantly.

**Why It Matters**

Preserves one of the few surviving examples of Maya mural painting at Chichén Itzá, depicting daily life rather than ritual scenes.

**Historical Context**

Deer were important in Maya culture for both food and ritual. The hunt scene suggests this building may have been associated with hunting ceremonies or a noble hunting lodge.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The deer mural was still partially visible in the 19th century but
- %æ Deer were associated with the sun god and the hunt was a noble

**Visitor Tip**

Bring binoculars or use your phone's zoom — faint traces of the deer mural survive high on the interior walls.

## 138. The Red House

*residential · Late Classic–Terminal Classic (800–900 CE)*

**Description**

Also called Casa Colorada, this well-preserved building retains traces of its original red paint. Its interior walls are covered with hieroglyphic inscriptions recording a dedication date of 869 CE.

**Why It Matters**

One of the few structures with a confirmed dedication date, anchoring the timeline of Chichén Itzá's late construction phase.

**Historical Context**

The red paint was made from cinnabar or hematite, precious pigments that signaled the building's importance. The inscriptions name a ruler named K'ak'upakal.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The dedication date 869 CE makes it one of the few precisely dat
- %æ Red was the color of the east, sunrise, and resurrection in Maya

**Visitor Tip**

Look at the interior walls — traces of the original red pigment are still visible after 1,100 years.

## 139. The House of the Phalluses

*temple · Terminal Classic–Early Postclassic (900–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A building named for the phallic carvings that decorate its facade, associated with fertility rituals. Some carvings were removed by early archaeologists due to their explicit nature.

**Why It Matters**

Represents the fertility cult at Chichén Itzá, where phallic symbolism was linked to agricultural abundance and regeneration.

**Historical Context**

Fertility imagery was common in Mesoamerican ritual art, though few surviving examples are as explicit as this structure's decorations.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Phallic imagery in Maya art symbolized fertility and the cycle of r
- %æ Some carvings were chiseled off by Victorian-era visitors who fou

**Visitor Tip**

Look carefully at the upper facade — a few of the original carvings survive if you know what to look for.

## 140. Temple of the Inscriptions

*temple · Terminal Classic (900–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A small temple once covered in Maya hieroglyphic inscriptions, now largely eroded. The remaining glyphs provide valuable records of dates and rituals from Chichén Itzá's history.

**Why It Matters**

One of the few structures at Chichén Itzá with extensive hieroglyphic texts, offering clues to the city's dynastic history.

**Historical Context**

The inscriptions mention dates and possibly rulers, but the Maya of Chichén Itzá used far fewer hieroglyphic texts than classic southern Maya cities.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Many inscriptions have eroded beyond recovery due to the soft li
- %æ The temple's name comes from the long text band that once ran a

**Visitor Tip**

Try to spot the few remaining glyph blocks near the door — each is a word or date in the Maya writing system.

## 141. The Steam Bath

*other · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

**Description**

A ritual sweat lodge (temazcal) used for purification before ceremonies. It has a small chamber, a fire pit, and a water basin where steam was created by pouring water on heated stones.

**Why It Matters**

Purification was essential before Maya rituals — the temazcal cleansed body and spirit for contact with the divine.

**Historical Context**

Temazcales were used across Mesoamerica for both ritual and medicinal purposes. This is one of the best-preserved examples at a Maya site.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The word 'temazcal' comes from Nahuatl: 'temaz' (steam) and 'cal
- %æ Similar sweat lodges are still used in parts of Mexico today for h

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the small doorway and the chimney vent — the engineering is remarkably similar to modern saunas.

## 142. The Ossuary

*temple · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

**Description**

A smaller stepped pyramid also called the High Priest's Grave. A shaft inside descends 12 meters into a natural cave where human bones and offerings were found — giving the structure its name.

**Why It Matters**

A funerary monument marking a sacred cave, connecting the surface world with the underworld through its internal shaft tomb.

**Historical Context**

The cave below the Ossuary was a ritual space long before the pyramid was built. The Maya believed caves were entrances to Xibalba, the underworld.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The shaft tomb contained jade, copper, and ceramic offerings alo
- %æ Serpent columns at the entrance mirror those of El Castillo on a

**Visitor Tip**

Notice the carved serpent heads at the base — a miniature echo of El Castillo's feathered serpents.

## 143. Venus Platform

*platform · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

**Description**

A small ornate platform near El Castillo dedicated to the planet Venus, the most important celestial body in Maya astronomy after the sun. Its carved panels show the Venus glyph and warrior imagery.

**Why It Matters**

Commemorated the Maya Venus calendar and the planet's dual role as morning star (war god) and evening star.

**Historical Context**

The Maya tracked Venus's 584-day cycle with extraordinary precision. Its appearances were times of both warfare and ritual, believed to influence earthly events.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The Maya associated Venus with war and would launch raids time
- %æ The platform aligns with Venus sightlines from El Caracol.

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the carved Venus symbols on the platform's sides — they resemble a shell or eye glyph.

## 144. La Iglesia

*residential · Terminal Classic (900–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A small, ornate building attached to Las Monjas, covered in elaborate stone carvings. Its facade is a gallery of symbolic animals: armadillos, snails, turtles, and the rain god Chaac — each representing different aspects of the Maya cosmos.

**Why It Matters**

A compact but densely symbolic structure, representing the Maya worldview through its carved animal iconography and serving as an elite ceremonial space.

**Historical Context**

La Iglesia was built as part of the Las Monjas complex expansion, reflecting the continued importance of this area as a seat of ritual and royal power through the city's history.

**Did You Know?**

%æ The four animals on the facade may represent the four bacabs — the cardinal directions.

%æ Despite its name, there's no evidence it was ever a church.

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the flying deity masks above the doorway — they represent the rain god Chaac in his role as a sky-bearer.

## 145. Las Monjas

*residential · Late Classic–Terminal Classic (600–1000 CE)*

**Description**

A grand complex originally called 'The Nunnery' by the Spanish, who thought its many small rooms resembled a convent. In reality, it was a palace for Maya royalty, covered in intricate stone carvings of masks, serpents, and deities.

**Why It Matters**

One of the oldest and most richly decorated structures at Chichén Itzá, showcasing the transition between classic Maya and the later militaristic styles.

**Historical Context**

Built in phases over centuries, Las Monjas shows distinct architectural layers — the earliest from the Late Classic period, with later additions reflecting the city's evolving political and religious identity.

**Did You Know?**

%æ The facade is covered in hundreds of Chac (rain god) masks stac

%æ An annex called 'La Iglesia' (The Church) was added later and fe styles.

**Visitor Tip**

Examine the facade carvings closely — you'll find Chaac masks, serpents, and even armadillos carved into the stone.

## 146. El Caracol

*observatory · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

**Description**

The Maya observatory — its name means 'the snail,' referring to the spiral staircase inside. The building's windows are aligned with specific celestial events, including the northernmost and southernmost settings of Venus.

**Why It Matters**

One of the most sophisticated astronomical observatories in the ancient world, demonstrating the Maya's mastery of celestial tracking and their reverence for the planet Venus.

**Historical Context**

The Maya tracked the cycles of Venus with extraordinary precision. Their calculations (584-day Venus cycle) match modern measurements almost exactly — an achievement unmatched in the ancient world.

**Did You Know?**

%æ The upper dome has sighting tubes aligned to track Venus at its

%æ The Maya Venus table in the Dresden Codex is accurate to within

%æ The building was built in phases, each layer adjusted to correct a

**Visitor Tip**

Notice the slitted windows in the upper tower — they're not decorative but precise astronomical sighting instruments.

## 147. Group of a Thousand Columns

*column group · Terminal Classic–Early Postclassic (900–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A vast colonnade of hundreds of stone pillars, each carved with the image of a warrior. The columns once supported a massive thatched roof, creating a great covered market or assembly hall.

**Why It Matters**

The largest columned hall in Mesoamerica, representing the economic and political power of Chichén Itzá at its peak as a regional capital.

**Historical Context**

Similar colonnades are found at Tula, the Toltec capital, reinforcing the theory of close ties between the two cities. The space may have served as a market, council chamber, or ceremonial hall.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ There are actually around 200 columns, not 1,000 — the name is
- %æ The columns are arranged in straight rows that create striking pe
- %æ Each column depicts a different warrior with unique headdress an

**Visitor Tip**

Stand among the columns and note how the spacing creates precise sight lines — the Maya designed this for ceremonial processions.

## 148. Temple of the Warriors

*temple · Terminal Classic–Early Postclassic (900–1200 CE)*

**Description**

A grand stepped temple flanked by hundreds of carved columns depicting warriors. At its summit sits a Chac Mool — a reclining stone figure holding a bowl on its stomach, possibly for sacrificial offerings.

**Why It Matters**

A monument to Chichén Itzá's military power, where warrior-society rituals and sacrifices were conducted under the gaze of the rain god Tlaloc.

**Historical Context**

The temple is architecturally influenced by Toltec styles from central Mexico, suggesting cultural exchange or a shared ruling lineage between the two regions.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The columns were originally painted in brilliant red, turquoise, ar
- %æ Over 200 warrior columns surround the temple, each carved with
- %æ The Chac Mool at the top is one of the finest examples of this my

**Visitor Tip**

Look for the murals on the inner walls of the upper temple — they show a great battle with warriors in canoes.

## 149. Platform of the Eagles

*platform · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

**Description**

A rectangular platform decorated with carved eagles and jaguars clutching human hearts. These animals were the avatars of the sun's journey through the sky and underworld.

**Why It Matters**

Symbolized the military orders of eagle and jaguar warriors — elite soldiers who captured victims for sacrifice to feed the sun and ensure cosmic order.

**Historical Context**

Eagle and jaguar warrior societies were pan-Mesoamerican military orders. Capturing enemies for sacrifice was a warrior's path to social advancement.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Eagles were associated with the sun and daytime; jaguars with th
- %æ The carvings show the animals holding hearts, representing the f

**Visitor Tip**

Compare the carving style here with the nearby Tzompantli — both use the same flattened, graphic approach to depicting the human form.

## 150. Tzompantli

*platform · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

**Description**

A low, wide platform covered in carved human skulls. Its name means 'Wall of Skulls' in Nahuatl, reflecting its function as a rack for displaying the heads of sacrificial victims.

**Why It Matters**

A monument to the power of death and sacrifice in Maya cosmology, symbolizing the cycle of life, death, and rebirth that sustained the universe.

**Historical Context**

Similar skull racks are found across Mesoamerica, from the Aztecs of Tenochtitlan to the Maya of the Yucatán, representing a shared belief in the sacred power of sacrifice.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ Each carved skull is slightly different, possibly representing actu
- %æ The platform may have held real skulls on wooden posts mounted

**Visitor Tip**

Walk around all four sides — the carvings include serpents eating human hearts alongside the skull motifs.

## 151. Temple of the Jaguars

*temple · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

**Description**

A small temple adjoining the Great Ball Court, adorned with carved jaguar motifs and murals depicting a great battle. Inside, a jaguar throne covered in jade and painted red was discovered.

**Why It Matters**

Dedicated to the jaguar — the most powerful predator of the Maya world and a symbol of royal authority and military might.

**Historical Context**

The temple's murals are among the few surviving examples of Maya battle scenes, likely depicting a historic military victory of Chichén Itzá over a rival city.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The murals show warriors in elaborate feathered headdresses wie
- %æ Jaguars were believed to be the spirit companions (wayob) of May

**Visitor Tip**

Look up at the carved columns — they show feathered serpents interwoven with jaguar imagery.

## 152. Great Ball Court

*ball court · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

**Description**

The largest and best-preserved Mesoamerican ball court, measuring 168 meters long. Its acoustics are extraordinary — a whisper at one end can be heard clearly at the other, 150 meters away.

**Why It Matters**

The ball game (pok-ta-pok) was not merely sport but a sacred ritual reenacting cosmic cycles, often involving human sacrifice of the defeated team.

**Historical Context**

The court features carved panels depicting the decapitation of a player, from which seven serpents spring — symbolizing fertility and rebirth through sacrifice.

**Did You Know?**

- %æ The acoustic properties are so precise they've been studied by m
- %æ The ball could weigh up to 4 kilograms and was struck with the hi
- %æ The hoop targets on the walls are only 30 cm wide — scoring was

**Visitor Tip**

Stand at one end and have a friend whisper from the other — the echo phenomenon is one of the site's most remarkable features.

## 153. El Castillo

*temple · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

**Description**

The iconic step pyramid of Kukulcan, standing 30 meters tall with nine terraced levels. Each side has a staircase of 91 steps; combined with the top platform, that's 365 — one for each day of the solar year.

**Why It Matters**

A masterpiece of Maya astronomy and architecture, designed so that on the spring and autumn equinoxes, sunlight creates the illusion of a giant serpent slithering down the pyramid's northern staircase.

**Historical Context**

Built atop an earlier pyramid, El Castillo encases a smaller temple within. Inside, archaeologists discovered a Chac Mool statue and a red jaguar throne inlaid with jade eyes.

**Did You Know?**

- The pyramid is a giant calendar in stone: 52 panels per facade re

calendar round.

- A second, older pyramid is hidden entirely inside this one.
- During the equinox, the shadow forms the body of Kukulcan, the f

**Visitor Tip**

Visit at sunrise or sunset for the most dramatic light on the pyramid's facades. The equinox serpent effect draws thousands — arrive early.

## 154. Sacred Cenote

*cenote · Late Classic – Terminal Classic (600–900 CE)*

**Description**

A deep natural sinkhole filled with emerald water, revered by the Maya as a portal to the underworld (Xibalba). Archaeologists recovered jade, gold, ceramics, and human remains from its depths — offerings to the rain god Chaac.

**Why It Matters**

The spiritual heart of Chichén Itzá's ritual life, where the Maya performed ceremonies to communicate with the gods of the underworld.

**Historical Context**

Dredging expeditions in the early 20th century recovered over 50 skeletons and vast quantities of precious offerings, confirming the cenote's role as a site of pilgrimage and sacrifice.

**Did You Know?**

- The water is 50 meters deep and partly fed by an underground riv
- Some offerings show marks of ritual heart extraction.

**Visitor Tip**

Walk the narrow sacbé (white road) that connects the cenote to El Castillo — it's the same ceremonial path the Maya used.

*Enjoy your journey through the ancient city of Chichén Itzá with NESS Wonders.*